

EAM310 · EAST ASIAN MEDICINE DIAGNOSIS I · VUIM

Week 3

Pulse Diagnosis · Pulse Qualities · Seasonal Pulses

Class: Friday July 25, 2026 · 9AM-1PM

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TCM for Ballroom Dancers | Dance Medicine Specialty

REQUIRED READINGS — DUE BEFORE JULY 25

- **FCM Chapter 25** — Maciocia: Normal pulse, 28 pulse qualities, clinical groupings
- **CAM Chapter 13** — Cheng Xinnong: Pulse diagnosis method & qualities
- **Handbook of Contemporary Pulse Diagnosis** — Leon Hammer (reference)

Week 3 Focus: 28 Pulse Qualities · Normal Pulse (胃神根) · Seasonal Pulses · Pulse Combinations · Six Climatic Qi Pulses

温故知新

PULSE POSITIONS — 寸關尺 · Both Hands

Hand			
LEFT	Heart / Pericardium	Liver / Gallbladder	Kidney Yin / Bladder
	Heart side Small Intestine (deep) · Upper Jiao	Middle Jiao	Lower Jiao (L)
RIGHT	Lung / Large Intestine	Spleen / Stomach	Kidney Yang / Bladder
	Lung side Chest · Upper Jiao	Middle Jiao	Lower Jiao (R) · Ming Men

Depth: Superficial = Yang/Exterior · Middle = Blood/SP-ST · Deep = Yin/Interior/KD · **Three positions × Three depths = 9 positions**

NORMAL PULSE — 胃 Wèi · 神 Shén · 根 Gēn

胃 Wèi Stomach-Qi	Flowing, gentle, harmonious — unhurried	Digestive function intact; always present in the living
神 Shén Spirit	Soft but with strength; regular; alive	Vitality of the Mind — good spirit = good prognosis
根 Gēn Root	Clearly felt deep at Chi (rear position)	Kidney Essence intact — constitutional root

NORMAL PULSE COMPONENTS

Rate	4 beats per breath · 60–80 bpm
Rhythm	Regular — no pauses or irregularities
Width	Moderate — not too thin or wide
Depth	Strongest at middle depth
Strength	Forceful with even pressure; not too strong/weak
Shape	Smooth, even, comes and goes easily

6-STEP PULSE READING SEQUENCE

①	Feel pulse as a whole
②	Check Spirit · Stomach-Qi · Root
③	Three levels & three positions
④	Strength of the pulse
⑤	Overall quality (if one exists)
⑥	Individual position quality

Factors affecting pulse: Time of day · Emotions/activity · Medications · Constitution · Season

Pulse (CN/ Pinyin)	How It Feels	Clinical Indication	Group / Key Note
DEPTH			
Floating 浮 Fú Mài	Distinct at superficial; fades slightly at deep — like wood floating on water	Invasion of external Wind; Yin deficiency (interior)	Combos: +Tight=Wind-Cold; +Rapid=Wind-Heat; +Empty=Yin def
Deep/Submerged 沉 Chén Mài	Only felt with heavy pressure, near bone	Interior patterns; Yang deficiency; organ-level issues	+Weak=Yang def; +Wiry=Blood stasis; +Rapid=interior Heat
Hidden 伏 Fú Mài	Press hard to bone — barely perceptible	Severe Yang deficiency; extreme cold obstruction; syncope	+Full=Qi/Blood stagnation; +Empty=severe Yang def
RATE			
Slow 遲 Chí Mài	<3 beats/breath (~40-60 bpm)	Cold pattern; Empty-Cold (Slow+Weak); Full-Cold (Slow+Full)	+Deep=interior Cold; +Slippery=Cold-Phlegm
Moderate 緩 Huǎn Mài	4 beats/breath; even, relaxed, slightly slow	Normal (if regular); Dampness; Spleen deficiency	Normal quality when relaxed; Dampness if sluggish
Rapid 數 Shuò Mài	>5 beats/breath (~90-120 bpm)	Heat pattern; Full-Heat (Rapid+Full); Empty-Heat (Rapid+Empty)	+Floating=Wind-Heat; +Wiry=LV-Fire; +Slippery=Phlegm-Heat
Hurried/Racing 疾 Jí Mài	>7 beats/breath (140-180 bpm) — extreme rapid	Fire exhausting Yin; extreme Heat	+Floating=severe Empty-Heat
STRENGTH			
Full/Overflowing 洪 Hóng Mài	Wide, forceful — rises strongly, fades gently. Like ocean waves	Full-Heat; Empty-Heat (Overflowing+Empty)	+Floating=Wind-Heat intense; +Slippery=Phlegm-Heat
Empty/Deficient 虛 Xū Mài	Wide but forceless at all three positions; sense of emptiness	Qi deficiency; general deficiency	+Floating=Qi/Blood def; +Slow=Yang def
Minute/Faint 微 Wēi Mài	Extremely thin and forceless; seems to come and go	Severe deficiency of Qi and Blood; near-collapse	+Rapid=Yin def+Empty-Heat; +Choppy=Blood exhaustion
Weak/Frail 弱 Ruò Mài	Forceless, deep, thin — only felt at deep depth	Yang deficiency; Blood deficiency	+Choppy=Blood def; +Slow=Yang def
SHAPE / WIDTH			
Wiry 弦 Xián Mài	Taut, long, forceful — like a guitar string	Liver disharmony; Pain; Phlegm; Spring (seasonal)	+Rapid=LV-Fire; +Slow=Cold in LV channel; +Tight=Blood stasis
Tight 緊 Jǐn Mài	Tense, like a twisted rope — bounces side to side	Cold patterns; Pain; Food retention	+Floating=exterior Cold; +Deep=interior Cold
Slippery 滑 Huá Mài	Smooth, rounded, quick — like a pearl rolling on a plate	Phlegm; Dampness; Food retention; Pregnancy	+Rapid=Damp-Heat/Phlegm-Heat; +Slow=Damp-Cold
Choppy/Rough 澀 Sè Mài	Rough, uneven — like scraping bamboo	Blood stasis; Blood deficiency; Yin deficiency	+Wiry=Blood stasis; +Weak=Blood def
Long 長 Cháng Mài	Extends beyond Cun and Chi positions	Heat patterns; Liver excess	+Rapid=internal Heat; +Wiry=LV disharmony

Pulse (CN/ Pinyin)	How It Feels	Clinical Indication	Group / Key Note
Short 短 Duǎn Mài	Cannot be felt in all three positions	Qi deficiency; Qi stagnation	+Choppy=Blood stasis + Qi def
Hollow 芤 Kōu Mài	Wide, soft; hollow in center — like a scallion stalk	Hemorrhage; forthcoming hemorrhage (Hollow+Rapid); Yin def	+Rapid=Yin def+Empty-Heat or hemorrhage
Soggy 濡 Rú Mài	Superficial, thin, forceless; weakens with pressure	Dampness; Qi/Blood deficiency	+Slow=Damp-Cold; +Rapid=Damp-Heat
Firm/Confined 牢 Láo Mài	Deep, taut, long, wide, forceful — only at deep depth	Blood stasis; Interior Cold; Pain	+Tight=internal Cold; +Slow=Cold+Blood stasis
Scattered 散 Sàn Mài	Wide, superficial, forceless, irregular — disappears on pressure	Collapse of Original Qi; critical condition	Serious sign — loss of Kidney foundation
RHYTHM (IRREGULAR)			
Hasty 促 Cù Mài	Rapid with irregular stops — urgently restless	Severe Heat; Heart-Qi deficiency; Heart-Fire	+Overflowing=HT-ST Heat; +Wiry=LV/HT Fire
Intermittent 代 Dài Mài	Regular pauses at fixed intervals	Serious internal organ disease; Heart problem (Western)	Most serious irregular pulse — organ failure sign
Knotted 結 Jié Mài	Slow with irregular stops	Cold obstructing; Qi stagnation; Phlegm; Blood stasis	Opposite of Hasty (Hasty=rapid+stops; Knotted=slow+stops)

SEASONAL PULSES 時令脈 — ★ HIGH YIELD ★

Spring 春	Wiry 弦 Xián Yang arising	Slightly tense, taut — if too tense = Tight pulse (pathology)	Yang Qi wants to arise but cold Yin obstructs → tension. Wiry in spring = NORMAL; too wiry or wiry outside spring → Liver disharmony	Feb 4 – May 4
Summer 夏	Flooding 洪 Hóng Full Yang	Wide, forceful, rises strongly — fades gently like ocean waves	Yang Qi completely uninhibited — rises & spreads outward. Flooding in summer = NORMAL; don't call excess without other signs	May 5 – Aug 6
Autumn 秋	Hair-like 毛 Máo Yin arising	Light, floating, delicate — "like elm pods falling through the air" (Su Wen); like a hair on skin surface	Yang Qi desiring to be restrained & collected. Light and empty = NORMAL in autumn	Aug 7 – Nov 6
Winter 冬	Stone-like 石 Shí Yang stored	Sinks deep — like a stone. Only felt at deep depth. Harder to feel = NORMAL	Yang Qi gathered and stored — when Yang retracts, pulse sinks. Students always struggle in winter — this is why	Nov 7 – Feb 3

⚠ **Late Summer (長夏):** Some texts add a 5th seasonal pulse — **Moderate/Soggy** 緩 Huǎn for Late Summer (SP/ST Damp season, roughly Aug). Maciocia mentions this in the Five Phase context.

SIX CLIMATIC QI → PULSE (From Slides)

Wind 風	Floating
Cold 寒	Tight, contracted, deep
Summer-Heat 暑	Floating, Vacuous
Dampness 濕	Soggy, Slippery
Dryness 燥	Short, Hasty, Rough
Fire/Heat 火	Restless, Rapid

SHANG HAN LUN STAGE PULSES

Taiyang 太陽	Floating
Yangming 陽明	Flooding or Long
Shaoyang 少陽	Wiry
Taiyin 太陰	Moderate (middle depth)
Shaoyin 少陰	Faint and Thin
Jueyin 厥陰	Thin, tendency to expire

KEY PULSE COMBINATIONS — TESTABLE

Combination	Clinical Meaning
Floating + Rapid	Wind-Heat invasion
Floating + Tight	Wind-Cold invasion
Floating + Empty	Yin deficiency (interior — NOT exterior)
Deep + Slow	Interior Cold
Deep + Rapid	Interior Heat
Rapid + Full	Full-Heat (Excess Yang)
Rapid + Empty	Empty-Heat (Yin deficiency)
Wiry + Rapid	Liver-Fire
Slippery + Rapid	Phlegm-Heat or Damp-Heat
Choppy + Wiry	Blood stasis
Overflowing + Summer	Normal seasonal (do NOT call excess)
Wiry + Spring	Normal seasonal (Liver only if too wiry or off-season)

PATTERN NAME	WEEK / QUIZ
DISEASE CATEGORY	ORGAN SYSTEM
ETIOLOGY	DATE

CLINICAL ESSENTIALS · TONGUE · PULSE · TREATMENT PRINCIPLE

TONGUE 舌診 · COLOR / COAT / SHAPE	CLINICAL ESSENTIALS

PULSE 脈診 · CUN · GUAN · CHI

Wrist	CUN 寸	GUAN 關	CHI 尺
L			
R			

TREATMENT PRINCIPLE

